

1985 ▶ 1990

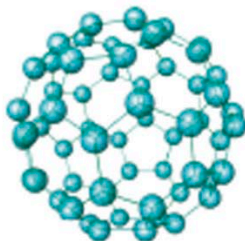


The first version of Microsoft's Windows operating system, called Windows 1.0, was launched on November 20, 1985.

1985

Buckyball (C₆₀)

Working at Rice University in Houston, British chemist Sir Harold Kroto and American chemists James R Heath, Sean O'Brien, Robert Curl, and Richard Smalley discovered buckminsterfullerene. Better known as C₆₀ or buckyball, this soccerball-shaped molecule consists of only carbon atoms. It is an allotrope—a different physical form—of the element carbon.



Computer-generated diagram of a buckyball molecule

1986

Disaster at Chernobyl

The worst nuclear disaster occurred at the Chernobyl nuclear power station in Ukraine when one of the four nuclear reactors at the site exploded. The blast released 400 times more radiation into the atmosphere than the atomic bomb dropped on Hiroshima, Japan, in 1945.



Abandoned school in a contaminated area near the Chernobyl disaster

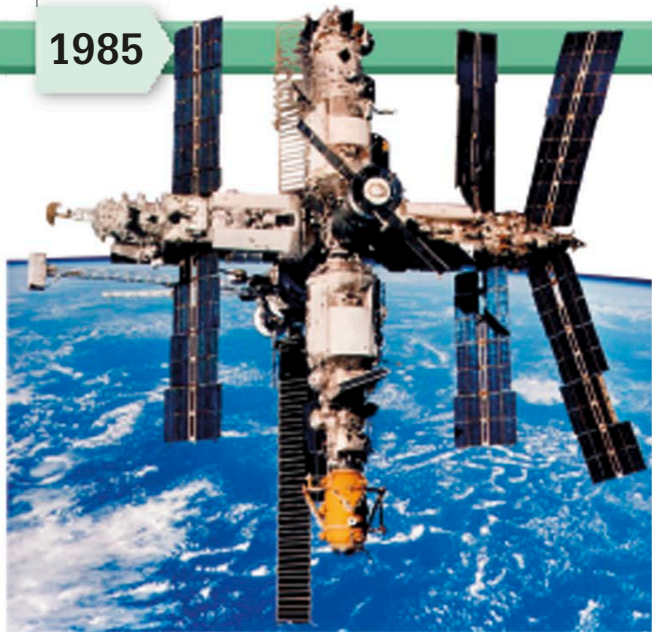
1986

Challenger disaster

The Space Shuttle *Challenger* exploded just 73 seconds after its launch from the Kennedy Space Center in Florida, killing all seven crew members on board. A faulty seal in one of the solid rocket boosters was responsible for the disaster. Other space shuttles were grounded for 32 months following the tragedy.



1985



1986

Mir Space Station

Russian Space Station *Mir* became the first space station to be assembled in Earth's orbit. It was 62 ft (19 m) long and could house three crew members permanently, with larger numbers accommodated for short periods. During its 15 years in orbit, 104 astronauts visited the station, including cosmonaut (Russian astronaut) Valeri Polyakov, who spent a record 437.75 days on board.

1987

The first statin

After long medical trials, a statin called Lovastatin was approved by the Food and Drug Administration (FDA) in the US. Statins are drugs that reduce the production of certain fatty substances in the body, including LDLs (low-density lipoproteins)—a type of cholesterol that can clog blood vessels and increase the risk of heart disease.



Lovastatin is found in oyster mushrooms and some other fungi.

1986

Atomic force microscope

German physicist Gerd Binnig, American physicist Calvin Quate, and Swiss professor Christoph Gerber invented the atomic force microscope. This powerful microscope uses an incredibly small probe to measure and make images of a sample's surface down to nanometers (billionths of a meter) in scale.



The world's first laser human eye surgery was performed by German ophthalmologist Theo Seiler in 1987.